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*Nozawa Bar is a small and intimate sushi bar experience
hidden within the Sugarfish by Sushi Nozawa.*



Chef Osamu Fujita

Executive Chef

Nozawa Bar, Beverly Hills

Chef Osamu Fujita, a long-time friend and colleague of Chef Nozawa, presides behind the bar at Nozawa Bar. Fujita was born into a long line of prestigious chefs in Japan, and from an early age, he immersed himself in Japan's culinary scene, studying with some of the country's most renowned chefs. As a young man, he brought his talents to US, where he worked for – and became friends with – Master Chef Kazunori Nozawa while working in Los Angeles. After years of working under Nozawa and other master chefs both in the US and Japan, Fujita embarked on a career as an Executive Chef, opening Japanese restaurants in San Diego, Miami, and Las Vegas. During this time, he served as Corporate Executive Japanese Chef, directing the opening of all Japanese restaurants in the U.S. for Hyatt Regency, Executive Chef for the Marssa Restaurant in Las Vegas, and as Corporate Sushi Chef for Loews Hotels. In 2003, Fujita received recognition as a Master Chef from the Japanese Chef Association in Tokyo, and in 2008, he received its Highest Achievement Award.



19 December 2023

Okinawa Kurage ・沖縄県の海月

Hokkaido Octopus ・北海道のタコのお刺身

New Zealand Pink Lobster ・ニュージーランド産のスキャンピ

Bluefin Tuna Akami from Baja California ・鮪の赤身

———— *Nigiri* ・握り ————

Akamutsu ・赤陸

Hirame Engawa ・平目の縁側

Hagatsuo ・歯鰹

Maine Lobster ・メインロブスター

Santa Barbara Uni ・サンタバーバラの雲丹

Isaki ・伊佐木

Iwashi ・鰯

Hokkaido Scallop ・北海道の帆立

————

Bluefin Kama Toro Sashimi ・カマトロのお刺身

Shigoku, Kumamoto, Kusshi Oysters ・「至極」、「熊本」、「屈指」カキ

Ankimo ・あん肝

———— *Nigiri* ・握り ————

Kinmedai ・金目鯛

Mirugai ・海松貝

Ikura Gunkanmaki ・イクラ軍艦巻き

Sawara ・鯖

Anago ・穴子

Maine Lobster Hand Roll ・メインロブスターの手巻き

Apricot Lane Farm Tamago Nigiri ・玉子の握り

———— *Dessert* ————

Mandarin Sorbet and Farmers Market Mixed Berries ・シャーベットとベリー

Hojicha Tea ・焙じ茶

Rainy night, right before eight-thirty.

I found myself standing at the threshold of Sugarfish, nestled right across the legendary Maybourne Hotel in Beverly Hills. Little did I know then, the impending hours would unfurl with a peculiar awkwardness.

It seems that a high-end, mysterious dining experience hidden inside a somewhat normal, or even uncomfortable, tumbledown place would be a new trend for fine dining. Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare shares the same location as the niche local market, who would expect a three-Michelin-star dining experience right behind the grocery shelves? Nōksu, the newly opened modern Korean diner, has set its location inside the 34th Street Herald Square subway station. And let's not forget the Frevo, concealed within the walls of an art gallery. This deliberate contrast serves as a potent tool, effectively stoking the curiosity and expectations of customers. Nozawa bar appears to be no different. Concealed within Sugarfish, a modest chain sushi diner, it promises a clandestine counter omakase encounter, rivaling the finest sushi establishments nationwide. However, what unfolds before me hardly distinguishes itself from the sushi served outside. In a few hours, my heart will mirror the chill of the rain.

At the front desk of Sugarfish, nobody comes to greet me. Observing the ceaseless stream of patrons and employees, I can't help but feel that I'll never have someone approach me in my lifetime. The response was curt: "Just wait outside!" It was a chilly, emotionless reply. Returning to the crowd outside, numbering around ten, I couldn't help but wonder: weren't we all guests awaiting entry to Nozawa Bar? As the clock struck thirty-four, four minutes past our reservation time, someone finally emerged to usher us in. We traversed the damp and chilly corridor devoid of light, only to be halted suddenly by our server, who embarked on an unexpected lesson! With enthusiasm, she enlightened us on the proper way to savor an omakase experience—how sarcastic! Despite years of indulging in omakase experiences, I still found myself humbly educated by a server. And as I glanced at the rest of our group, and without surprise, their eyes widened with excitement, eagerly absorbing every morsel of knowledge and nodding in agreement, reminiscent of a cohort of primary school students on their very first day of school.

At last, the lesson concluded. We ventured across the wooden threshold into the omakase room—a cramped space with an awkward layout. Unlike the typical linear sushi counter found in most omakase establishments, Nozawa Bar featured an L-shaped counter, evenly dividing the guests on both sides. I found myself seated right at the center corner, with barely any room to maneuver. Before the dinner even started, the waiter recklessly bumped into my chair three times, and even insisted that I should shift forward, despite the limited space available. What a ludicrous situation, exacerbating the discomfort of the cramped quarters.





Dinner unfolds rather promptly, beneath the solemn scrutiny of Chef Fujita. His somewhat unhappy gaze seems to hint at a temperament issue, though it's possible that language could be the barrier contribute to the impression. Regardless, the first otsumami dish arrives swiftly, showcasing Kurage from Okinawa. While ingredients shouldn't be subject to hierarchy, jellyfish isn't typically associated with high-end omakase experiences anyway. Yet, vinegar-marinated jellyfish often graces Chinese dinner tables, and here, it fails to rival even canned jellyfish I used to have. The acidity lacks balancing, and the jellyfish's texture falls short of expectations.

Next up on the menu are three sashimi selections, showcasing Hokkaido octopus, New Zealand pink lobster, and bluefin tuna akami cuts from Baja California. From a purely geographical perspective, I have all the right to suspect that, diversity, a current trendy word for HR circles, has permeated even the culinary realm. In this petite dish, I traverse three continents like a headless fly. While one could extend a gesture of mercy and acknowledge the valid reasons for sourcing octopus from Hokkaido and lobster from New Zealand, the rationale behind Baja California's bluefin tuna seems dubious, perhaps driven solely by cost considerations. Consequently, the flavor profile leaves much to be desired, offering a regrettable gastronomic experience. None of the trio exhibits significant umami richness; instead, all that greets the palate is a bland, lackluster sensation.

The haphazard conclusion of the otsumami courses is marked by the disappointing nature of the sashimi offering. It stands out as the most scrawled otsumami session I've ever encountered in a sushi omakase experience. Nonetheless, the dissatisfaction doesn't end there; the sushi course that follows reveals an even greater scam — a pure joke awaits.

As the chefs start to prepare sushi, I kindly ask for the source and variety of the rice they use. I am not expecting an elaborate shari blend of 30% Yumepirika rice from Hokkaido and 70% Koshihikari rice from Miyagi as seen in Ginza Onodera, yet I am expecting something serious, at least something to show that the chef cares about the shari.

As I posed my question, the chef paused, then muttered: "H Mart." In that instant, a cold sensation gripped my heart, leaving me feeling like a foolish clown. To make matters worse, he went on asking, "Do you know what H Mart is?" For me, this was not only an insult to me but also to the chef himself. Clearly, he had no boundaries left. Of course, the response about H Mart was a joke, as he proceeded to ramble about his belief that shari should be made from a blend of different rice varieties, depending on the season. He seemed to think he could dazzle me with his pretentious discourse, perhaps assuming I was an ignorant diner he could easily deceive. However, no amount of elaborate descriptions could mask the fact that he couldn't even name the rice he used. This alone made it clear that this establishment is nothing but a scam.



Just as I thought things could never get worse, the chefs shocked me again with megawatts of lightning striking my head, leaving me petrified into an ashy sculpture with a stunned and bewildered face. Sushi omakase before a counter is what I can think of as the most sacred ceremony celebrating the heavenly marriage of shari and the fishes, yet what Nozawa Bar is in nature is a sushi factory. A line cook prepares the shari, shaping it into a ball in such an inferior way just as kindergarten kids shape the clay, and passes it to the next station where the fish are cut and prepared. Ultimately, the chef assembles shari and the ingredients like Lego blocks. It's debatable whether to call it shari, or simply a rice ball. Chef Fujita's actions, or lack thereof, are not just shocking but disgraceful to the sushi tradition, his attire, his blade, and the revered wooden counter.

The nigiri session starts unconventionally with an array of flavor bombs, each representing a different dimension of sensation that one may find satisfying at first but may interfere with the subsequent nigiri journey. The first nigiri served is a nodoguro nigiri, followed by hirame engawa, and then hagatsuo. Nodoguro has an unusual amount of fat for a white fish, while a little bit of grilling is usually applied to amplify the fatty aroma, its richness is still prominent when enjoyed raw. A touch of yuzu salt seems proper for enhancing the flavor of the nodoguro. Moving on to the hirame engawa, it is both chewy and fatty due to the high amount of collagen and fat it contains, which boasts umami and delicate sweetness. A touch of spring onion adds an additional depth to the richness. The last flavor bomb is the hagatsuo, a fattier version of katsuo in the winter season. Compared to the two white fishes, hagatsuo carries a unique yet more dense umami that somehow reads metallic and smoky akin to a tuna cut. Just like the engawa, the hagatsuo is also seasoned with spring onion. If it isn't the awful shari that destroyed its marriage with the fishes, the nigiri would be far more enjoyable. That being said, it's crucial to enhance the precision and preparation of the fish.

Up next, the Maine lobster nigiri with a touch of yuzu is served, yet it appears rather underwhelming. What is supposed to highlight the lobster's sweetness and umami ends up merely serving as a palate cleanser. Following that, the Santa Barbara Uni proves notably disappointing in quality, devoid of the anticipated sweetness and overshadowed by an overpowering oceanic odor. However, all the other guests couldn't resist praising it, repeating that they had never experienced sea urchins of such exceptional quality before. On that, I have no doubts. Another three pieces of nigiri follow, marking the conclusion of the first half of the nigiri course, albeit with disappointment. The Isaki lacks flavor and its texture leans towards rubbery, and the repeated inclusion of spring onion feels almost annoying at this stage. Following this, the introduction of Iwashi seems rather abrupt, as its intense fishy aroma clashes oddly with the delicate nature of the Isaki and the impending Hotate. Seasoned with garlic ginger puree and spring onion, the Iwashi is unfortunately overshadowed by the pungent garlic taste. Lastly, the Hotate, adorned with yuzu salt, presents itself with a thickness that overwhelms the palate, coupled with a yuzu salt that proves too assertive for such a refined delicacy.







The abruptly ceased otsumami course now finds its rear part as a trio of interludes arrives. Yet the disappointment continues. To start with, thinly sliced Kamatoro sashimi is served. Enough raw fish with strong flavors have been served up to now, and it won't hurt to sear the kamatoro a little bit to bring out its ultimate fatty aroma, but the chef just opts against it. Flavorless in nature, the rich greasy fattiness makes me sick, and the rubbery seaweed just makes things worse. Following this, a miniature oyster tasting is served, a somewhat perplexing choice. Sourced from Vancouver, the Shigoku and Kusshi oysters, alongside the Kumamoto from Seattle, provide an odd juxtaposition. It is strange to see two distinct varieties coming from the same city in a tasting setting, and the quality of the oysters is inferior as expected. Among them, only the Kusshi oyster leaves a lingering impression with its relatively notable fruity oceanic flavor profile. Lastly, the presentation of Ankimo, the final otsumami dish, unquestionably marks the low point of the dining experience. Never before have I encountered such a terrible execution of Ankimo. Crushed to a sandy texture, it not only proves unpleasant on the palate but also destroys the intended silky texture and flavor of this delicacy. This is nothing but a reckless waste.

The latter half of the sushi course now continues, presenting five pieces of sushi with no logical connection. First up is the Kinmedai, whose flavor is completely overshadowed by the nauseating interference of Ankimo. Next is the toothy and crunchy Mirugai, accompanied by Shiso, Himalayan pink rock salt, and lemon juice, a rare decent offering. However, the subsequent Ikura Gunkanmaki is disappointing. The ikura is not fresh, lacking the desired burst, and the overflow of ikura presented in a flashy manner is wasteful and awkward for diners. The Sawara that follows is similarly unsatisfactory; not only is the flesh of poor quality, but the preparation lacks finesse, failing to bring out its flavor adequately. And the final piece, the customary Anago, is even more disagreeable. Despite the chef's insistence on avoiding overly sweet anago, the sauce is excessively heavy, overwhelmingly tasting of koikuchi, the most intensive soy sauce, making it almost impossible to swallow. The texture of the Anago is also inferior. Though tender, it is too loose, concluding the meal on a dismal note.

Surprisingly, in this latter part of the entire dinner, the chef's attitude undergoes a startling transformation. From being somewhat detached at first, he suddenly morphed into an social butterfly, sporting not only a libertine smile but also engaging with the guests in a overly relaxed manner. Yes, Americans indeed enjoy this kind of atmosphere, but as a sushi chef, crafting dishes with finesse should be the priority. Engaging with guests without regard for flawless culinary execution is not only perplexing but also highly disrespectful to the sushi. The chef smiled as he inquired about everyone's origins and professions, creating a noisy atmosphere throughout the restaurant, completely devoid of the solemnity that sushi demands.







In the coda of the omakase, the spotlight shifts to the sous-chef from Morocco. Speaking fluent Japanese and appearing quite professional, his presentation and technique, however, left much to be desired. He presents us with a Maine lobster hand roll that immediately exposes the mediocrity of his technique. The seaweed is unpleasantly soggy, and the lobster lacks flavor, completely overpowered by the sauce. Mostly disappointingly, the texture of the lobster is reminiscent of frozen crab, rubbery and dry. Overall, it is essentially an Americanized imitation roll showcasing Mayonnaise.

Next, Chef Fujita takes the rudder back, initiating a grandiose tamago performance. Tamago here is definitely beyond ordinary yet in a questionable direction. Aiming for innovation, the chef stuffs umeboshi and shiso into the tamago right in front of us and cuts the tamago with a flamboyant knife skill. Unfortunately, beneath the dazzling performance lay a dish that is merely superficially impressive. The intrinsic aroma of the tamago is completely overpowered by the intense salinity and acidity of the umeboshi. The excessive use of umeboshi, heavy-handed, utterly ruined the tamago.



Eventually, the omakase concludes with a Mandarin sorbet soaked in plum wine jus with farmers market mixed berries. As an adaptation for American stomachs, the sorbet dessert is arguably the most satisfying dish of the omakase experience, how sarcastic. A cup of warm hojicha arrives alongside, consoling my heart that is chilled to the core by the dinner with its scant warmth.

Adding to the review is my final protest to the service here. Besides the initial chaos I experienced, several more issues came along the omakase experience. First of all, this establishment seriously lacks human resources. There is only one waitress in the room and she seems to lack the ability to handle everything. Bumping into my chair several times within a short time frame, dropping utensils here and there. She does not have the power to even manage the basics, how would I expect her to have the remaining ability to address my questions and concerns? Moreover, the kitchen is not only lousy with chaos and noise but also with no logic, the order in which they present dishes to guests is disorganized. If this place gets one Michelin star, how could Yoshino New York be entitled to the same honor instead of getting three stars?



Lastly, I must talk about the general atmosphere of the omakase restaurants across the country. While this observation might not be deemed suitable for public discourse, within the realm of fine-dining in the United States, the nuanced landscape of high-end sushi omakase warrants a dual narrative. One trajectory is steeped in authenticity and tradition, epitomized by chefs who exude a quiet, unassuming demeanor, their singular focus dedicated to delivering an experience mirroring Japan's esteemed sushi establishments. These culinary artisans and restaurants include the legendary Yoshino in New York, Sushi Amane, once under the tutelage of the young yet immensely gifted Shion Uino, now running 69 Leonard Street, and the notably distinguished Sushi Noz. Chef Nozomi of Sushi Noz, in particular, embodies an commitment to excellence. While he remains gracious and warm towards patrons who demonstrate a reverence for both the ingredients and the artistry of his cuisine, his demeanor can swiftly turn curt towards those who disrupt the serene ambiance or fail to promptly savor his creations. On occasion, he has been known to retrieve sushi pieces that have languished untouched for too long on the plate or to expeditiously escort unruly guests out of his sushi sanctuary.

In contrast, the world of the second type of sushi establishment unfolds with a contrasting scene, one frequented by American clientele for business gatherings or romantic rendezvous. It is important to understand that my remarks are rooted not in discrimination but in a keenly objective observation. This demographic often exhibits a surface-level intrigue in Far Eastern culture, borne more from unfamiliarity than genuine depth of understanding. They perceive dining at upscale Asian establishments as a badge of sophistication, believing it enhances their image among their circle of socialization. However, their knowledge of sushi remains rudimentary at best. Many remain uninitiated in the elemental trinity of tuna—Akami, Chutoro, and Otoro—let alone the more esoteric realms of Chiaigishi and Kamatoro. Furthermore, the nuances of sushi etiquette often elude them, as they carry their boisterous American conviviality right up to the sushi counter. It appears that the chefs at these establishments are indifferent, perhaps refraining from tradition in favor of catering to local palates. Their primary goal seems to be crafting sushi that pleases the American palates, prioritizing their satisfaction above all else. This ethos finds its embodiment in the celebrated yet notably deficient-in-skill Sushi Nakazawa. However, amidst this landscape, one can still discover exceptional gems where the chef's mastery is evident, and the ambiance is imbued with a vibrant energy that bridges both worlds seamlessly. Noda in New York, a personal favorite of mine, stands as a shining example of such culinary excellence. Today's experience at Nozawa Bar proves to me that this place is among the second type, and it must be one of the worst, even for this category. The rest of the guest group consists of no Asians but all Americans and the way they praise this place, whether they pretend or mean it seriously, suggests that they do not have the basic knowledge and won't be interested in serious sushi omakase experiences. Chef Fujita sees that and provides a meal that is good for Instagram. Will Chef Fujita's intrinsic respect for this job awaken? Only time will tell.